

WORLD WAR I DEFENCES

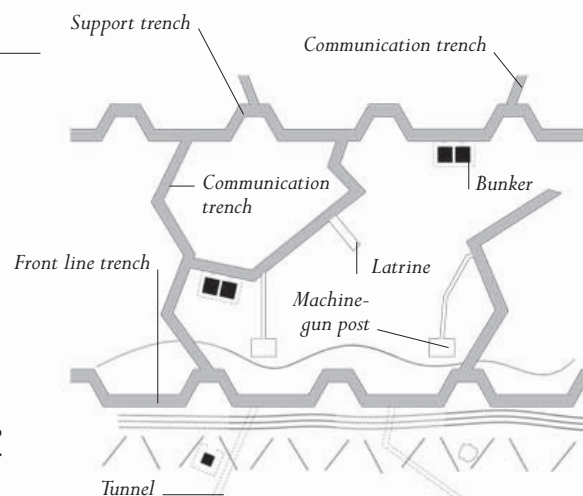
BAYERNWALD TRENCH

For much of World War I, a line of trenches ran for 700km (435 miles) from the Belgian coast to the Franco-Swiss border west of Basel. Bayernwald was a German trench near Ypres, in Flanders.

Following the “Race to the Sea” after the Battle of the Aisne, in September 1914, the opposing armies dug in to face each other. At first, the trenches they excavated were little more than ditches, but as the deadlock persisted trenches evolved into permanent fortifications incorporating bunkers and protected by belts of barbed wire. The “no-man’s-land” between the opposing lines was sometimes as little as 25m (28 yards) wide, but was typically 10 times that.

The height of the trench walls was generally well over that of the soldiers,

their sides “revetted” with timber, wattle, corrugated iron, and sandbags, and their bottoms lined with planks. Strongpoints were constructed using poured concrete or pre-fabricated blocks brought in at night. The nature of the trenches varied with the terrain, but in low-lying areas like Flanders they were always at risk of flooding, and daily life was a constant struggle against the mud. Since the Germans took up their positions first, they often had the advantage of choosing higher ground that was drier and less exposed to enemy fire.



PLAN VIEW

▲ SIMPLIFIED GERMAN TRENCH SYSTEM

Reserve troops and supplies were moved from the support trench to the front via communication trenches, along which telephone lines also ran.

TRENCH STRUCTURE



► FIRESTEP

A simple wooden framework supported a step on which a man could stand to fire over the parapet. This was a risky business, so many soldiers equipped their rifles with a form of periscope.

◀ TRENCH LINE

Trenches followed a meandering, zig-zag path. This gave some protection to the occupants against shrapnel and blasts from artillery rounds and grenades. It also prevented an enemy who had managed to break in from firing along the trench.



▲ SHALLOW TRENCH

Built in a raised location overlooking the enemy, the Bayernwald trench could be shallower than usual yet still protect troops from direct fire.



▲ CROSS-TIMBER

Trenches were bridged with timber beams; they supported roof sections, telephone lines, or hoses to pump out water.

